

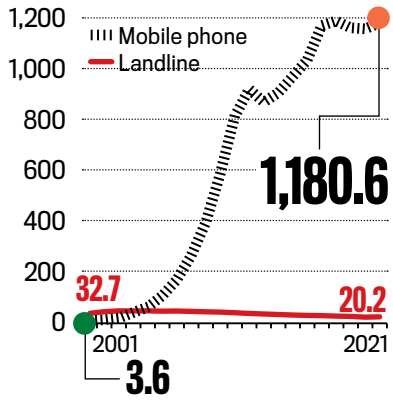
TALKING TERMS
A cellphone tower brings connectivity to rural Rajasthan, 2015

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

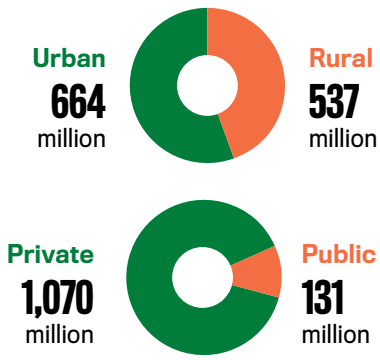
TELEPHONY

THE MOBILE REVOLUTION

TOTAL SUBSCRIBERS
(In million)



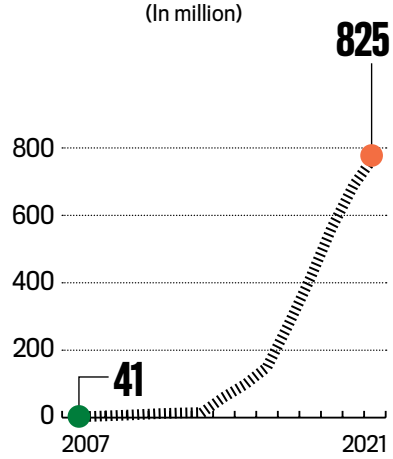
COMPOSITION OF MOBILE PHONE SUBSCRIBERS
At the end of March 2021



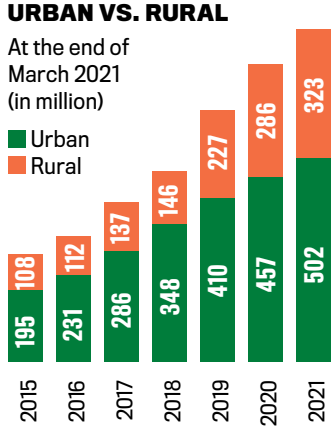
INTERNET

NET GAIN

TOTAL SUBSCRIBERS
(In million)



INTERNET USERS: URBAN VS. RURAL
At the end of March 2021 (in million)



Sources: TRAI, DoT

to make 5 million lines per year, but it did not fructify. It was at Rajiv Gandhi's behest that technocrat Sam Pitroda set up C-DOT (Centre for Development of Telematics) as an autonomous R&D body in 1984. The following year, the department of telecom was hived off from the posts and telegraph department. A year later, the Mahanagar Telephone Nigam Ltd (MTNL) was set up to handle telecom services in Mumbai and Delhi, and the Videsh Sanchar Nigam Ltd (VSNL) to drive overseas services. The year 1994 saw the birth of a national telecommunications policy, and the arrival of mobile telephony the year after revolutionised the telecom landscape further. The sector acquired a watchdog in TRAI (Telecom Regulatory Authority of India) in 1997. From 2002 onwards, select private players were allowed to provide both basic and cellular service.

Today, India is the world's second-largest telecom market after China, with 1,181 million subscribers. The country is now on the cusp of introducing 5G telephony, having recently completed auctions for spectrum. ■